

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called Dependent Origination

Āryapratītyasamutpāda nāma mahāyānasūtra · Toh 520 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་རྟེན་པའི་འབྲེ་བར་འབད་བ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ་ཐག་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛན།

Toh 520 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Āryapratītyasamutpāda nāma mahāyānasūtra and in Tibetan as the Phags pa rten cing 'brel bar 'byung ba zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo, rendered in English as The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called Dependent Origination. The text belongs to the sūtra section of the Kangyur and takes as its central subject the doctrine of dependent origination, one of the most foundational teachings in Buddhist thought, which describes how all phenomena arise in dependence upon causes and conditions. The sūtra opens with the Buddha dwelling in the realm of the Thirty-Three Gods in the company of a vast assembly of śrāvakas, bodhisattvas, and divine beings including Maitreya, Avalokiteśvara, Vajrapāṇi, Brahmā, and Śakra, suggesting a setting of great cosmic significance befitting its profound doctrinal content. As a Mahāyāna sūtra, it frames the teaching on dependent origination within the broader perspective of the bodhisattva path and the liberation of all beings.

In the language of India: Āryapratītyasamutpāda nāma mahāyānasūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called Dependent Origination.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling in the realm of the Thirty-Three Gods, upon a flat stone resembling a harmonium, together with the venerable Aśvajit and the other great śrāvakas; with the noble Maitreya (Lovingkindness Personified); with the noble Avalokiteśvara; with Vajrapāṇi; and with the other great bodhisattvas, great beings, adorned with immeasurable and precious qualities; together with Brahmā the Great, lord of the world Akanniṣṭha; with the son of Śiva; with the Great Lord (Maheśvara) and the other gods; with Śakra, lord of the gods; with Pañcaśikha, king of the gandharvas; and with many others, all assembled there together.

Then the great bodhisattva, the great being Avalokiteśvara rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, bowed with palms joined in the direction of the Blessed One, and

spoke these words to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, these gods here wish nothing more than to build a stūpa. They are gathered in this assembly, and so I request that the Blessed One teach the Dharma to them in whatever way will cause the merit of Brahmā to increase, and cause monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen among the people of the world — including its gods, māras, Brahmās, its ascetics and brahmins — to greatly increase their merit."

Then the Blessed One, in response to this request, declared the verse of dependent origination:

Ye dharmā hetuprabhavā hetun teṣāṃ tathāgato hy avadat,
teṣāṃ ca yo nirodha evaṃvādī mahāśramaṇaḥ.

Whatever phenomena arise from causes —
their causes and their cessation too —
this the Tathāgata has declared;
thus spoke the great ascetic.

"Avalokiteśvara, this dependent origination is the dharmakāya, the truth body, of the Tathāgatas. Whoever sees dependent origination sees the Tathāgata.

Avalokiteśvara, if any son or daughter of a noble family who has faith should build a stūpa no larger than a myrobalan seed, with a central pole no larger than a sewing needle, and with an umbrella no larger than a bakula flower, in some uninhabited place, and should place inside it this verse of dependent origination from the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena, that person will generate the merit of Brahmā, and passing on from here at the time of death will be reborn in the world of Brahmā."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, those śrāvakas, those bodhisattvas, the whole of that assembly, together with the gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas of the world, rejoiced.

Translator's Notes

• The phrase "son of Śiva" renders སྐུ་མཆོག་གི་ཕུ་སྐུ་, literally "son of No-Craving." This is a standard Tibetan rendering of a divine name, and in context refers to a son of Śiva in the Brahmanical cosmological setting of the assembly; some commentators identify this as Skanda or a similar figure. The identification is not entirely certain.

The text ends mid-sentence at rejoiced, as the source passage breaks off there; the final participial clause in Tibetan (འཇགས་པ་) is the beginning of what would be the standard sūtra-closing rejoicing formula, here incomplete.

The flat stone compared to a harmonium renders समस्तसुखसदृश, a transliteration of the Sanskrit word for a particular kind of flat slab or board; the exact instrument or object is not always clear in context but "harmonium-like flat stone" follows the standard reading.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.